

Chapter 1 — Introduction

1.1 Background and Context

Indian banking is changing quickly. Banks now rely on digital systems for customer service, payments, compliance, risk management, and internal communication. Employees therefore need regular opportunities to update their knowledge and skills. Training is no longer limited to a classroom. It may include online modules, live virtual sessions, mobile learning, face-to-face workshops, practice activities, and on-the-job guidance. This change is especially important in public-sector banks, where a large and geographically distributed workforce must follow common procedures while responding to new technologies and regulations. It also requires training that can reach employees across locations without interrupting essential banking work for long periods. The training must also be clear enough for employees to use new knowledge confidently, accurately, and consistently when serving customers and completing routine operational tasks.

Hybrid learning, also called blended learning, brings together digital and face-to-face learning. The digital component can make training easier to access and can allow employees to learn at a suitable time. The classroom component can support discussion, demonstration, practice, and immediate clarification. When these parts are planned as one programme, employees can first study basic ideas online and then use classroom time to ask questions, solve problems, and practise work-related tasks. The value of hybrid learning, therefore, does not come simply from using two delivery methods. It depends on how well the two methods are connected.

This issue matters in banking because employees must apply training in their daily work. A new product, regulatory requirement, digital service, or customer-service procedure cannot be learned only by reading material on a screen. Employees also need opportunities to discuss difficult points, practise procedures, and receive guidance. At the same time, it is not always practical to bring all employees to a central training location. Digital learning can reduce travel and help employees revisit important material. A well-designed hybrid programme may offer both flexibility and practical support.

The sequence of activities is important. Online material can be used to introduce concepts, rules, and procedures before a workshop. A trainer can then use the face-to-face session for examples, demonstrations, case discussions, and questions that employees may find difficult to address alone. After the workshop, a digital refresher, quiz, or job aid can help employees recall the material when they return to work. If the parts are not connected, however, employees may experience the programme as a set of unrelated activities. They may repeat the same content, miss an important link between theory and practice, or find the digital component difficult to use. The study examines employees' experience of the whole hybrid programme, including the way its digital and classroom elements are connected.

Research suggests that hybrid learning can contribute to positive workplace outcomes, although the results depend on the learning environment. Agarwal, Goyal, Kumar and Modi (2026) studied a hybrid employee-development programme in financial services. Their programme combined instructor-led sessions, e-learning, a gamified simulation, on-the-job learning, and live projects. Participants showed greater performance improvement than a comparison group. The study shows that a combined programme can support employee development, but it does not identify which part of the programme produced the improvement.

Saroj, Sahney and Sekar (2026) provide a closer explanation of how blended workplace training may work. In their study of employees in an Indian organization, acceptance of blended learning, instructor competence, and employees' metacognitive skills were linked with learner engagement. Engagement was then associated with employee agility. Their findings are useful because they show that a training format alone is not enough. Employees must be interested, attentive, and willing to participate. Trainers must also be able to guide learners in both digital and face-to-face parts of a programme.

Union Bank of India provides a suitable setting for this study. The bank has a formal learning system that includes the Union Bank Knowledge Centre, regional training facilities, and a digital learning platform known as Union Vidya. These arrangements show that the bank already uses the main elements of hybrid learning. The purpose of this study is not to introduce a new training system. It is to understand how employees experience the existing combination of digital and in-person learning and how that experience is related to training outcomes.

The study focuses on a practical question for human-resource and learning-and-development functions: which features of hybrid learning help employees become engaged with training and use what they learn at work? A clear answer can help the bank design training that is convenient for employees without losing the discussion, support, and practice that face-to-face learning can provide. It can also help decision-makers direct training resources towards the aspects of a programme that employees find most useful.

This dissertation examines hybrid learning as a connected learning system. It considers hybrid learning and trainer competence as conditions that may influence learner engagement. It then examines whether engagement is linked with training effectiveness, knowledge retention, and job performance. The study asks how digital and in-person learning can work together in a corporate setting.

1.2 Key Concepts and Definitions

Learning is the process through which a person gains knowledge, skills, or the ability to perform a task more effectively. In this study, learning refers to a change that can be used in an employee's work.

Training is organized learning provided by an employer for a specific work-related purpose. It may develop technical knowledge, procedural knowledge, customer-service skills, managerial skills, or other capabilities needed in the organization.

Digital learning refers to learning supported by technology. It may include online courses, learning-management-system modules, recorded videos, mobile-learning applications, online assessments, and virtual classrooms. Digital learning can provide flexibility because employees may access material at a convenient time and revisit it when needed. **In-person learning** refers to classroom or workshop-based training where employees and trainers meet directly. It is useful for live discussion, demonstration, feedback, role play, and practical exercises.

Hybrid learning or blended learning is the planned integration of digital and in-person learning. Garrison and Kanuka (2004) explain blended learning as more than the simple presence of online and classroom activities. The two modes should support each other. For example, an employee may complete an online module before attending a workshop that applies the same content to realistic banking situations. In this study, hybrid learning includes flexibility, access to digital material, interaction, ease of using training technology, and the connection between online and classroom sessions.

Trainer competence refers to a trainer's ability to help employees learn. A competent trainer understands the subject, explains it clearly, uses the available training tools effectively, and encourages

participation. In hybrid learning, trainer competence also includes the ability to connect online and classroom activities. Saroj, Sahney and Sekar (2026) identify instructor competence as an important condition associated with learner engagement in workplace blended learning.

Learner engagement refers to the attention, effort, interest, and active participation that an employee brings to training. An engaged learner does more than attend a session or complete an online module. The learner concentrates on the material, participates in activities, and tries to understand how the content can be used. Schaufeli, Bakker and Salanova (2006) describe engagement through vigour, dedication, and absorption. In this study, engagement is treated as the link between the design of training and the results employees obtain from it.

Training effectiveness refers to the extent to which training achieves its intended purpose. It includes whether employees understand the content, consider it relevant to their role, and can use the knowledge or skills in their work. Kirkpatrick's (1994) training-evaluation framework distinguishes reaction, learning, behaviour, and results. This study treats training effectiveness, knowledge retention, and job performance as related but separate outcomes. An employee may be satisfied with a programme but still fail to remember the content or apply it later.

Knowledge retention is the ability to remember and recall training content after the training event has ended. It is different from immediate understanding at the end of a session. Retention matters because employees often need to use training knowledge weeks or months after completing a course. Wakekar et al. (2026) found higher delayed knowledge-retention scores among participants in a blended-learning group than among participants in single-mode groups. This supports the decision to measure retention separately in the present study.

Job performance refers to how well an employee carries out core work duties. The study uses the task-performance aspect of job performance, such as accuracy, quality, efficiency, and the use of work-related knowledge. This approach follows the distinction between task performance and broader citizenship behaviour discussed by Williams and Anderson (1991) and Koopmans et al. (2011, 2014). The study does not assume that training automatically improves performance. It tests whether retained knowledge is associated with employees' own perceptions of their job performance.

1.3 Need, Scope and Significance of the Study

The need for this study arises from both organizational practice and the existing literature. Public-sector banks invest in training because employees must keep pace with changing products, systems, customer expectations, and regulatory requirements. Union Bank of India has a large workforce and formal learning infrastructure. It is therefore important to understand whether employees experience the bank's hybrid training as useful and whether this experience is connected with learning and work-related outcomes.

The literature reviewed for this dissertation points to four related gaps. First, many studies report whether blended learning is associated with positive outcomes, but fewer examine the process through which it may influence those outcomes. Ashraf et al. (2021) note that engagement and related learner characteristics are often discussed as outcomes rather than tested as explanatory mechanisms. This study responds by examining learner engagement as a mediator between the conditions of training and training effectiveness.

Second, a large share of blended-learning research has been carried out in higher education. Employees in a bank learn in a different setting from students. Their participation may be shaped by work pressure,

organisational expectations, customer responsibilities, and the immediate need to apply learning on the job. Bin Mubayrik (2018) identified a much smaller body of workplace blended-learning research than higher-education research. The present study focuses only on employees in a corporate setting.

Third, there is limited research on hybrid learning in Indian public-sector banking. Jain and Jain (2015) examined training effectiveness across Indian banks, but their study did not examine hybrid learning. The review undertaken for this dissertation did not identify a verified study that tested the present model within Union Bank of India. The study therefore offers evidence from a setting that has received little direct attention in the literature.

Fourth, existing studies usually examine only part of the proposed outcome sequence. Saroj, Sahney and Sekar (2026) examine engagement and employee agility. Wakekar et al. (2026) examine knowledge retention after training. These studies provide useful evidence, but they do not test the full pathway from hybrid learning through engagement, training effectiveness, retention, and job performance. The present study brings these links together in one model.

The scope of the study is deliberately limited. It examines employees of Union Bank of India who have taken part in training that includes both digital and face-to-face components. It does not compare separate groups receiving only digital training or only classroom training. The study uses a cross-sectional survey and relies on employees' self-reported experiences. Knowledge retention and job performance are measured through employees' perceptions. The study does not use a delayed knowledge test or supervisor ratings. These limits should be kept in mind when interpreting the findings.

The study has academic and practical significance. Academically, it adds evidence on corporate blended learning in Indian public-sector banking. It also examines learner engagement as a possible explanation for the relationship between hybrid learning and training outcomes. Practically, it can help the Learning and Development function at Union Bank of India identify what employees need from a hybrid programme. Findings on digital access, integration of learning modes, trainer competence, engagement, retention, and workplace application can guide future training design.

For the organization, the results may help answer practical design questions. Some content may be suitable for independent digital study, while other content may require a trainer-led demonstration or discussion. Employees may also need enough time, clear instructions, and easy access to digital resources before they can benefit from the online part of a programme. The study does not prescribe one fixed balance between digital and in-person learning. It examines the conditions that employees associate with an effective hybrid-learning experience. The findings can help improve the design of future programmes and guide decisions about the use of technology in training.

The study does not attempt to make broad claims about all banks or all employees. Its findings will reflect one organizational setting and one group of respondents. Even so, the study can offer useful insight into the challenges of combining digital and in-person learning in a large public-sector organization.

1.4 Statement of the Problem

Union Bank of India uses both digital and face-to-face learning facilities to support employee development. However, the presence of these facilities does not by itself show that employees are engaged with training, retain what they learn, or apply it effectively in their work. A hybrid programme may be convenient and accessible, but it may still be ineffective if digital and classroom activities are poorly connected or if employees do not receive clear guidance from trainers.

The problem addressed by this study is the limited understanding of how hybrid learning contributes to training effectiveness among employees of Union Bank of India. In particular, it is not clear whether employees' experience of hybrid learning and their perception of trainer competence are associated with learner engagement, and whether this engagement is linked with training effectiveness, knowledge retention, and job performance.

The study therefore examines the following pathway: Hybrid Learning and Trainer Competence influence Learner Engagement; Learner Engagement influences Training Effectiveness; Training Effectiveness influences Knowledge Retention; and Knowledge Retention influences Job Performance. The study asks whether these relationships are present among employees who have experienced blended training at Union Bank of India.

1.5 Industry Profile and Company Profile

Industry Profile: Indian Public-Sector Banking

Public-sector banks play an important role in India's banking system. Their size, wide branch networks, and public responsibilities make employee training a continuing requirement. The sector has also experienced major changes in technology, regulation, digital payments, cybersecurity, and customer expectations. Employees need to understand new systems and processes while continuing to provide reliable service to customers.

The public-sector banking sector was shaped by nationalization in 1969 and 1980 and by later consolidation. A major consolidation took effect in April 2020, when several public-sector banks were merged. These changes increased the need for common systems, common procedures, and employee development across large workforces. Training is therefore not a one-time activity. It is part of how banks maintain service quality and support organisational change.

Digital systems have also changed how banks can deliver learning. Learning-management systems, mobile applications, virtual sessions, and online assessments can make training available to employees across different locations. Classroom sessions remain important for discussion, practice, problem-solving, and clarification. For this reason, hybrid learning is relevant to the public-sector banking sector. It can combine the reach of digital learning with the support offered through direct interaction.

Company Profile: Union Bank of India

Union Bank of India was founded in 1919 and nationalized in 1969. In April 2020, Andhra Bank and Corporation Bank were merged with Union Bank of India. The bank is now one of India's large public-sector banks, with approximately 8,650 or more domestic branches and about 74,000 employees according to its corporate profile and recent disclosures (Union Bank of India, n.d.-a). Its size and geographic spread make a formal, scalable learning system necessary.

The bank has an established training infrastructure. The Union Bank Knowledge Centre at Bannerghatta, Bengaluru, serves as a residential staff-training facility. The bank also maintains training centres and learning facilities in different regions. Its Human Resources communications describe employee learning and skill development as an important part of the bank's people strategy (Union Bank of India, n.d.-b).

Alongside face-to-face training, the bank uses Union Vidya, a digital learning platform that gives employees access to training content through mobile technology. The platform includes learning

materials, interactive scenarios, quizzes, and progress tracking (Union Vidya, n.d.). The bank has also issued a request for proposal for a learning-management-system subscription, indicating continuing investment in digital-learning infrastructure (Union Bank of India, n.d.-c). These facilities make Union Bank of India an appropriate setting for a study of hybrid learning because employees can experience both online and in-person elements of training.

The bank's training context is also relevant because its workforce has had to adapt to continuing technological and organisational change. The 2020 amalgamation brought together employees from three banks, while digital banking has increased the need for current product, process, and technology knowledge. In this setting, it is useful to examine whether hybrid training supports employee engagement and whether learning is retained and applied at work.

This study is situated at Union Bank of India's Regional Office Chennai South, located at 38 and 39 Whites Road, Express Estate, Royapettah, Chennai, Tamil Nadu 600014. This provides a clear organizational setting for examining employees' experiences of blended training. The analysis is based on the experiences reported by employees who have participated in such training. It does not assume that every employee receives the same programme or uses the same digital platform in the same way.

1.6 Chapterization

This dissertation is organized into five chapters.

Chapter 1 introduces the study. It explains the background of hybrid learning in Indian public-sector banking, defines the main concepts, states the need and scope of the study, presents the research problem, and describes the industry and the organization selected for the study.

Chapter 2 reviews the literature on hybrid learning, trainer competence, learner engagement, training effectiveness, knowledge retention, and job performance. It presents the theoretical basis for the conceptual model and identifies the research gaps addressed by the study.

Chapter 3 explains the research methodology. It presents the objectives, hypotheses, variables, research design, sampling approach, data-collection procedure, questionnaire, and methods of data analysis. It also discusses the planned reliability and validity checks.

Chapter 4 presents and interprets the survey findings. It reports the profile of respondents, descriptive results, reliability results, and tests of the proposed relationships between the six constructs.

Chapter 5 summarizes the findings, discusses their academic and practical implications, identifies the limitations of the study, and presents recommendations for future research and training practice.